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Impartial Analysis
Measure "Y"
Belmont Community Center Measure

Measure "Y" asks Belmont voters whether to approve an ordinance levying a special tax for constructing and operating a new community center in the City of Belmont. Measure "Y" was placed on the ballot by a citizen initiative petition proposed by the group "Friends of Belmont Community Center" and signed by more than 10% of registered Belmont voters. The measure requires a simple majority vote to pass.

If enacted, Measure "Y" would provide dedicated local revenue for the sole purpose of funding community center operations and services. To this end, the measure authorizes a tax on the square footage of improvements in the city beginning July 1, 2027, and establishes rates of 33¢ per square foot of improvements for dwelling units and 54¢ per square foot of improvements for all other property. The tax does not apply to parcels and improvements exempt from taxation by law and to the dwelling unit of persons age 65 and older who own and reside in the dwelling unit. Exemptions require annually eligibility verification.

The measure requires revenue from the tax be deposited into a "Community Center Special Fund" and restricts uses of that fund to construction, operations, staffing, maintenance, repair, and capital improvement of the new community center, administrative expenses associated with the tax, and for maintaining, improving, and expanding the community center's programs. Because the use of the revenue is restricted to these purposes, the tax is considered a special tax. The Community Center Special Fund would be controlled exclusively by the City of Belmont for those purposes and cannot be controlled or taken by the State.

The measure contains a list of spending priorities within the scope of the Special Community Center Fund to be considered by the City when spending the Fund. The priorities include certain types of capital, operational and programmatic expenditures related to the community center including: fire prevention, earthquake resistance, disaster relief, and other emergency preparedness; senior, adult, youth, and teen programs; supervised children's play, childcare and after-school programs; indoor and outdoor recreation areas; health, wellness, and fitness programs; improving accessibility and energy efficiency; and maintaining weekend and evening hours and appropriate staffing.

The measure is estimated to generate approximately $7.1 million for the Special Community Center Fund in the first tax year. The City Council may increase the tax rate by the percentage increase in specified regional inflationary or personal income growth indexes beginning in tax year 2028-2029. All other increases may only be authorized by the voters and the tax authorization would continue until ended by voters. The measure increases the City's appropriation limit under Article XIIIB of the California Constitution for four years by an amount equal to the revenue derived from the tax. The measure requires annual audits on the expenditure and administration of the tax.

California courts have held that a special tax measure proposed by citizen initiative requires only a simple majority vote to pass.

A "yes" vote would approve the measure and the levy.

A "no" vote would reject the measure.

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